

20 — Ancestries (the catalog)

The full roster of playable ancestries. Character creation (02-character-creation.md) keeps a six-race starter set and points here for the rest — the same way it points to 19-classes.md for the class roster.

How an ancestry works

Pick **one ancestry**. It gives you exactly two things, at level 1:

- **+1 to one ability** (fixed per ancestry — a nudge toward a role, never a lock). The lone exception is the **Human**, whose +1 goes anywhere.
- **One Racial Signature** — a single trait. It is **one of your two level-1 signatures** (the other is your Class Signature, 19-classes.md). You get exactly **one**, always.

A "trait" here is a small **bundle**, not a single clause — look at the classics: the Dwarf's is "*darkvision **and** advantage vs. fear/charm*," the Elf's is "*dim-light sight **and** advantage on Perception*." Every trait below is tuned to that same power level. No ancestry stacks two traits; the catalog is large because **families have many members**, not because anyone gets more.

Families are flavor, not a mechanical layer. "Elf" or "Dragonborn" is a grouping for browsing. You choose **one member** (e.g., *Wood Elf*) and get its one ability and one trait. There is no "base trait + subrace trait."

The trait toolbox (for the GM building new ancestries)

Every trait is built from effects already in the game. The legal palette:

- **Advantage** on a named skill, or on a defense vs. a condition (fear, charm, Poisoned...).
- A **sense** — dim-light sight, or darkvision (see in the dark ~30 ft).
- **1/rest**: reroll a d20; or drop to 1 HP instead of 0.
- **Movement**: Speed 8; a swim or climb speed; breathe water; move through larger creatures' spaces; ignore a kind of difficult terrain; glide (no fall damage).
- **Resistance** to one damage type (take half).
- **Pack Tactics** — advantage on attacks while an ally is adjacent to your target.
- **Innate magic** — know one **cantrip** (cast with your primary, 0 mana), or a specific **1/rest** Lesser spell (e.g., *Misty Step*), no mana.
- **Breath weapon** — 1/rest, a Close 2-square cone; roll **d20 + primary** vs. each creature's Armor for **2d6** of an element.
- **Natural weapon** — claws / horns / bite, a **1d6** weapon you always carry (uses your primary).
- **Flat +1 to a static defense** (e.g., natural +1 Armor — bounded, like Bulwark).
- A **narrow immunity** (can't be magically slept; immune to disease) or **cosmetic shapeshift**.

The fundamentals stay off-limits. No racial bonus to **attack rolls**, to the **training bonus**, or to **mana-pool size**; no **extra action**; no **stacking +1 s on a d20**. Flat bonuses to *static defenses* are fine. If a homebrew trait would touch one of those, it's out.

Humans & half-folk

Ancestry	+1	Racial Signature
Human	any	Adaptable — gain one extra training at creation.
Half-Elf	Charisma	Beguiling Grace — advantage on Persuasion; see in dim light.
Half-Orc	Might	Savage Blows — your critical hits roll one extra damage die; advantage on Intimidation.

Elves — tall, long-lived, born to an older world. Elves trance rather than sleep (flavor).

Ancestry	+1	Racial Signature
Wood Elf	Agility	Keen Senses — advantage on Perception; see in dim light. (<i>the classic Elf</i>)
High Elf	Mind	Fey Schooling — see in dim light; know one Illusion or Destruction cantrip .
Drow	Charisma	Underdark Born — darkvision ; know one Illusion cantrip.
Sea Elf	Spirit	Tidecaller — swim speed = your Speed; breathe water.
Eladrin	Charisma	Fey Step — cast <i>Misty Step</i> 1/rest , no mana.

Dwarves — stone-steady, clan-proud, deep-delving.

Ancestry	+1	Racial Signature
Mountain Dwarf	Might	Stone-Hearted — darkvision ; advantage on Charisma defense vs. fear & charm. (<i>the classic Dwarf</i>)
Hill Dwarf	Spirit	Dwarven Resilience — darkvision ; advantage on defense vs. Poisoned.
Duergar	Mind	Gray Dwarf — darkvision ; advantage on your Mind defense vs. spells.

Halflings — small, warm, harder to kill than they look.

Ancestry	+1	Racial Signature
Lightfoot Halfling	Agility	Lucky — 1/rest, reroll any one of your d20s and take the new result. (<i>the classic Halfling</i>)
Stout Halfling	Spirit	Stout Gut — resistance to poison; advantage on defense vs. Poisoned.

Gnomes — small, clever, endlessly curious.

Ancestry	+1	Racial Signature
Forest Gnome	Mind	Forest Cunning — know <i>Minor Illusion</i> ; advantage on Stealth.
Rock Gnome	Mind	Tinker's Mind — advantage on Crafting and on your Mind defense vs. spells.
Deep Gnome	Agility	Stone Camouflage — darkvision ; advantage on Stealth in stone or underground.

Goblinoids — scrappy, canny, built for the fight.

Ancestry	+1	Racial Signature
Goblin	Agility	Scurry — Speed 8 ; move through the space of any larger creature. (<i>the classic Goblin</i>)
Hobgoblin	Mind	Saving Face — 1/rest, reroll a failed attack or check if an ally is within Near.
Bugbear	Might	Long-Limbed — your melee reach is +1 square ; advantage on Stealth.
Kobold	Agility	Pack Cunning — advantage on attacks while an ally is adjacent to your target.

Orcs — fierce, enduring, hard to put down.

Ancestry	+1	Racial Signature
Orc	Might	Savage Reserves — 1/rest, when you'd drop to 0 HP, drop to 1 instead. (<i>the classic Orc</i>)
Half-Orc	(see Humans & half-folk)	

Dragonborn — drake-blooded, proud, marked by an element.

Each carries a **Breath** (1/rest Close cone, 2d6 of its element) and **resistance** to that element. *(Chromatic and metallic dragonborn are flavor reskins of these five elements.)*

Ancestry	+1	Element
Flame Dragonborn	Charisma	fire
Frost Dragonborn	Might	cold
Storm Dragonborn	Charisma	lightning
Acid Dragonborn	Might	acid
Venom Dragonborn	Might	poison

Tieflings — fiend-touched, charismatic, walking a hard road.

All Tieflings see in **dim light**. *(Other infernal lineages reskin these five.)*

Ancestry	+1	Racial Signature
Infernal Tiefling	Charisma	Hellfire Blood — resistance to fire; know <i>Spark</i> .
Abyssal Tiefling	Charisma	Demon-Marked — resistance to necrotic; know <i>Daze</i> .
Glasya Tiefling	Charisma	Silver Tongue — advantage on Deception (Persuasion); know <i>Minor Illusion</i> .
Levistus Tiefling	Charisma	Frostblood — resistance to cold; advantage on defense vs. Frightened.
Zariel Tiefling	Might	Warbrand — resistance to fire; advantage on Intimidation.

Aasimar — light-touched, burdened with a calling.

Ancestry	+1	Racial Signature
Protector Aasimar	Spirit	Celestial Ward — resistance to radiant and necrotic.
Scourge Aasimar	Spirit	Searing Soul — 1/rest, deal 2d6 radiant to one creature you touch or hit.
Fallen Aasimar	Charisma	Shadowed Halo — resistance to necrotic; advantage on defense vs. Frightened.

Genasi — elemental-blooded, each a different temper.

Ancestry	+1	Racial Signature
Fire Genasi	Charisma	Ember Soul — resistance to fire; know <i>Spark</i> .
Water Genasi	Spirit	Tideborn — swim speed = your Speed; breathe water.
Air Genasi	Agility	Windborn — resistance to lightning; you take no falling damage.
Earth Genasi	Might	Stoneborn — ignore rocky difficult terrain; you can't be knocked Prone against your will.

Beastfolk — kin to the wild things.

Ancestry	+1	Racial Signature
Tabaxi <i>(catfolk)</i>	Agility	Cat's Grace — climb speed = your Speed; claws (1d6).
Leonin <i>(lionfolk)</i>	Might	Mane & Claw — claws (1d6); advantage on Intimidation.
Lizardfolk	Spirit	Hardened Hide — natural +1 Armor ; hold your breath up to 15 minutes.
Minotaur	Might	Goring Charge — horns (1d6); if you move 2+ squares straight at a foe, the hit deals +1d6 .
Turtle	Spirit	Shell — natural +1 Armor ; hold your breath up to 1 hour.
Shifter	Agility	Beastshift — 1/rest for 1 minute, gain claws (1d6) and Speed 8.
Grung <i>(frogfolk)</i>	Agility	Clammy Climb — climb speed = your Speed; advantage on defense vs. Poisoned.

Winged folk — at home in the air.

Ancestry	+1	Racial Signature
Aarakocra <i>(birdfolk)</i>	Agility	Gliding Flight — glide (no fall damage); 1/rest, fly your Speed once on your turn.
Kenku	Agility	Mimicry — glide (no fall damage); advantage on Deception of voices and sounds.
Fairy	Charisma	Pixie Step — glide (no fall damage); know <i>Minor Illusion</i> .
Owlin	Mind	Silent Wings — see in dim light; advantage on Stealth while airborne or in shadow.

Sea & deep folk

Ancestry	+1	Racial Signature
Triton	Spirit	Child of the Deep — swim speed = your Speed, breathe water; resistance to cold.
Locathah <i>(fishfolk)</i>	Agility	Finned — swim speed = your Speed; natural +1 Armor (scaled hide).
Plasmoid <i>(ooze)</i>	Agility	Amorphous — squeeze through any gap a fist can pass; resistance to acid.

Fey & uncanny folk

Ancestry	+1	Racial Signature
Satyr	Charisma	Fey Revel — advantage on Charisma defense vs. charm & fear; advantage on Persuasion through performance.
Changeling	Charisma	Many Faces — at will, alter your appearance to any humanoid of your size (cosmetic only); advantage on Deception.
Firbolg	Spirit	Wild Step — advantage on Wilderness; move through natural difficult terrain freely.
Centaur	Might	Charger — Speed 8; if you move 2+ squares straight at a foe, the hit deals +1d6 .
Goliath	Might	Mountain-Born — advantage on Endurance; ignore rocky difficult terrain.
Harengon <i>(rabbitfolk)</i>	Agility	Hare-Trigger — 1/rest reroll a d20; you take no falling damage.
Yuan-ti <i>(serpentfolk)</i>	Charisma	Serpent's Guile — resistance to poison; advantage on your Mind defense vs. spells.

Made & ageless folk

Ancestry	+1	Racial Signature
Warforged	Might	Integrated Plating — natural +1 Armor ; immune to disease; you needn't eat, breathe, or sleep.
Autognome <i>(clockwork)</i>	Mind	Built to Last — immune to disease and poison; advantage on defense vs. Poisoned.
Vedalken	Mind	Dispassionate — 1/rest, reroll a failed Mind-based check; advantage on defense vs. Charmed.
Reborn <i>(revenant)</i>	Spirit	Deathless — advantage on defense vs. Frightened; immune to disease, and you needn't breathe.

What ancestry doesn't decide

- Your class.** The +1 nudges, it doesn't gate — a Might-favoring Orc can be a caster; a Charisma Tiefling can swing a greataxe.
- Your pool, perks, or signatures-beyond-the-racial.** Those come from class and level (19-classes.md, 03-progression.md).
- Language, age, height as stats.** Flavor only (02-character-creation.md).

If a player wants an ancestry not listed, the GM builds one from the toolbox above: **+1 to one ability + one trait of comparable power**. That's the whole recipe.